

Smooth Blue Aster

Symphiotrichum laeve

Smooth Aster



QUALITIES

A graceful prairie aster 2 to 3 feet tall, with smooth blue-green claspng leaves on slender arching stems. From September into October it produces a cloud of inch-wide sky-blue daisies with yellow centers, often the last major bloom in the Minnesota prairie before frost. The smooth foliage and tidy form distinguish it from many of its weedier aster cousins.

CARE

Full sun is best; tolerates light shade. Average to dry soil; tolerates drought, clay, and lean conditions. Deer-resistant. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. Pinch back stems in early June to encourage compact branching and reduce any tendency to flop. Self-seeds modestly. Long-lived and clump-forming rather than aggressively spreading.

HISTORY

Asters were among the most diverse and difficult plant groups for early North American botanists; the genus has been split, lumped, and renamed multiple times — the modern *Symphiotrichum* is a 1995 reorganization of the old North American "asters." Indigenous peoples used various asters in smoke for hunting medicine and as a diaphoretic tea. Smooth blue aster specifically appears across the prairie-forest border subsection of Minnesota's pre-settlement vegetation map.

REASON TO BE

Smooth blue aster is the closing act of the prairie season — when bergamot and coneflower are setting seed, this aster lights up the bed in cool sky-blue. It is a critical late-season nectar source for migrating Monarchs and queen bumblebees fattening for hibernation. The Pearl Crescent butterfly uses it as a larval host. Its reliable upright form and rich blue color make it the easiest aster to slot into formal designs without the wild-edged look of New England aster.